move positioned Najm Ṣānī on the border of the desert, well-known to the Aūzbegs, with ‘Ubaid on his flank in Bukhārā.

As for what transpired next, the sources vary, offering brief and sometimes conflicting accounts. They diverge more in the choice of details to record than in the description of the same events. Their most significant difference is in terms of timing, with one account suggesting a few days and another four months. However, these periods might not pertain to the same event, and it is mentioned that the siege lasted for four months, indicating a substantial duration.

Initially, there were minor engagements with varying outcomes, and supplies began to run low. Both Najm Ṣānī’s officers and Babur himself urged a retreat. However, Najm Ṣānī remained resolute and refused to listen to their advice. Eventually, ‘Ubaid Khān rode out from Bukhārā with a formidable force and joined the Ghaj-davān garrison. The united Aūzbegs took position in the suburbs of Bukhārā, where walled lanes and gardens restricted the battlefield and diminished Najm Ṣānī’s numerical advantage. On Tuesday, Ramẓān 3rd (12 November of AD 1512),[9] a decisive battle was fought, resulting in the routing of Najm Ṣānī’s army and his own death.

f) Babur and Yār-i-aḥmad Najm Sānī

Some writers suggest that Najm Ṣānī’s soldiers did not fight well, but it’s important to consider that they may have been weakened by deprivation, and their desire to retreat. Regarding Babur, it is said that he, as the reserve, did not participate in the battle at all. It’s difficult to find a compelling reason why, given the circumstances, he should risk the loss of his men. It appears that Haidar’s strong language about this defeat would align with Babur’s disposition as well. He wrote, ‘The victorious breezes of Islam overturned the banners of the schismatics . . . Most of them perished on the field; the rents made by the sword at Qarshī were sewn up at Ghaj-davān by the arrow-stitches of vengeance. Najm Ṣānī and all the Turkmān amīrs were sent to hell.’

The belief that Babur had failed Najm Ṣānī persisted at the Persian Court, and his inaction was later used as a reproach to his son Humāyūn in AD *1544 when latter sought refuge with Ismā‘īl’s son Ṭahmāsp. Badāyūnī shares a story, although with significant inaccuracies in names and places, which reflects the view held at that time. The relevant part of the anecdote suggests that on the eve of the battle at Ghaj-davān, Babur shot an arrow into the Aūzbeg camp, bearing a couplet that expressed his ill-will toward the Shāh and perhaps also his rejection of the Shī‘a guise he had previously adopted. I made the Shāh’s Najm road-stuff for the Aūzbegs.*

If fault has been mine, I have now cleansed the road.[10]